

Massif was covered with a light mantle of regolith a few yards thick. This had been produced by a rock avalanche, possibly triggered when the area was bombarded by boulders ejected when the nearby Tycho Crater was formed. As the Moon is being

continuously bombarded by asteroids, the number of craters per unit area increases with time. There are relatively few craters on the Taurus-Littrow Valley floor, which was taken to indicate that the surface is even younger than the Apollo 12 landing site. One crater in the valley, Shorty, was once thought to be a volcanic vent, but more detailed analysis of its raised rim and central mound indicated that, like millions of other lunar craters, it was produced by an impacting asteroid.



SPLIT ROCK

This house-sized boulder was ejected from an impact crater in the Mare Serenitatis and then rolled down into the valley. Scoop marks can be clearly seen where some samples have been taken from its surface.

EXPLORING SPACE

MOON GLASS

The lunar regolith contains large amounts of volcanic glass. This occurs as glazings on rock fragments and also as tiny teardrop- and dumbbell-shaped droplets. Colors range from green and wine-red through to orange and opaque. The orange glass found near Shorty was typical of high-titanium lunar glasses, but it was also rich in zinc.

ORANGE SOIL IN SHORTY CRATER

The glassy orange surface soil was excavated by an impact about 20 million years ago. It was actually formed about 3.6 billion years ago.

